state, we believe Tamil insurgents would resist the Indians as they now do the Sinhalese. In our view, if Indian intervention were not soon followed by a settlement between Colombo and the insurgents, violence would again flare between the Island's communities, but this time with Indian forces caught in the middle.

Most Disastrous Spy Operation and Saving Grace

Sri Lanka remains one of the R&AW's most disastrous espionage operations ever. The political decisions to first support the insurgents and subsequently turn the guns against them had little gains for India besides holding onto influence in the neighbouring country for a few decades. The spies believe India's reaction in 1983 had been appropriate when the decision to support the insurgents was taken, as the country could not remain unmoved by atrocities against ethnic Tamils. But the battle was too long and arduous. Sustaining a covert operation for more than two decades doubled the danger. Plus, international community pressure was clear—terrorism in Sri Lanka must stop. The UPA thus gave its support to Mahinda Rajapaksa and so did its ally, the DMK, and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi.

Any debate over the DMK's support to Rajapaksa against the LTTE was clarified by a US embassy cable dated 27 October 2008 titled 'Karunanidhi concern mostly political theatrics,' based on a conversation between the US ambassador to Sri Lanka and the Sri Lankan president. The cable said:

Ambassador asked for the President's views on how far he expected Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Karunanidhi to press the Indian government on Sri